

the rise of India and China; now post-facto we glibly assert that culture can be changed by politics and the parts that cannot be altered may actually be an asset. It had been said that state forms will hamper growth; China's authoritarian state has been an asset for growth. In short, the story of how societies will evolve will fundamentally be a tale of improvisation rather than a pre-set script that Zakaria's convergence thesis seems committed to.

But his throwing cold water over American anxieties is a prelude to the most sensible part of the book: new rules for the American foreign policy. These include—and emphasise on—long-term priorities rather than derailment of foreign policy by short-term crises, building broad rules rather than narrow interests, a stake in the politics of engaging other big powers rather than balancing them, investing in a more multi-layered global governance system that can handle various crises, being supple in the choice of instruments, and recognising that legitimacy is power. Zakaria's message that the more open the US remains, the more likely it is to secure its legitimacy is appropriate, particularly at a time when intellectual support for a more open global order is diminishing in the country.

But a more interesting question would be to probe further how Zakaria's rules will play out in practice. For the fundamental question that he skirts is: how much is the US willing to let go of its hegemonic status? On some interpretations, these rules are a ruse to secure its hegemony, not transform it. At a high level of generality, these rules are so sensible that it is a bit of a wonder why they had been ignored. Merely blaming Bush would be too easy and would belie the role American intellectuals and civil society consistently played in overestimating both the power and the innocence of American foreign policy. When you overestimate your own power and are convinced of your moral claims, it is a fatal combination. Zakaria is a classic modernisation theorist, a firm believer in the Whig narratives of progress. But whether politics in the West and in the Rest will be conducive to this narrative, remains an open question. ■



The Boy Luck Club

Male angst has never seemed less attractive than in two new books about young men making their way through Indian academia



BOMBAY RAINS, BOMBAY GIRLS
by ANIRBAN BOSE
HarperCollins
Price: Rs 195
Pages: 454



KEEP OFF THE GRASS
by KARAN BAJAJ
HarperCollins
Price: Rs 195
Pages: 259

■ By Kaveree Bamzai

A quick question. Can anyone explain why boy-lit has to be so boyish? Why does it have to be only about grades, girls and good jobs? Why does every page has to have at least one f-word and no, we don't mean football? And why does every philosophical question have to be routed to *The Matrix* (at least God, let it be *The Godfather*)? Such existential meanderings strike you pretty early on in the pages of Karan Bajaj's *Keep off the Grass*. Bajaj is, no doubt, a bright young man and he is, no doubt, an asset to society but Agastya Sen he is not. In this reverse *Inscrutable Americans*, a 25-year-old Yale graduate working in Wall Street who seems to have it all, a la Bret Easton Ellis, is stricken by homesickness and decides to move to India, first to IIM-Bangalore, and then to a job selling soap in small town India. Marijuana, masturbation and monologues pepper this book as Bajaj's Indian American hero looks for the deeper meaning in life, hurtling from one cliché to another—A. Banjaaran's

Dark Prophecy! Vipassana! Sex with a foreigner! Male bonding!

Bajaj is not the only one reading too many Chetan Bhagats. Anirban Bose's *Bombay Rains, Bombay Girls* also does a switch on the professional institute, here substituting IIT with a Mumbai medical college, which our hero enters at 18, fresh from Ranchi, picking up a rainbow coalition of friends along the way. There's the usual quota of ragging, rabidly boring dissections on cadavers, and exchange of roses. Nothing amounts to much but at the end of the story, it appears, the hero has become a man—and acquired a much-needed girlfriend. Which makes one think. What next, a boy-lit book on life in the advertising industry, in the television business, in an oil refinery firm? I have a sneaking suspicion that publishers plan to spring these on unsuspecting readers over the next few months. Which is why I recommend a deep breath and a strong dose of Nick Hornby. Nothing beats his rendering of boys-turning-into-men. Just a tip for the next boy-lit writer. Try him. Forget Bhagat. ■